80 AWESOME PHRASES TO WOW YOUR Teachers!

Easy-to-use phrases to describe emotions. Suitable for Primary School Compositions.

JERRY LEE

Contents

How to Use this Guide 3
Phrases to Describe Happiness 4
Phrases to Describe Sadness 7
Phrases to Describe Anger 10
Phrases to Describe Fear 13
Phrases to Describe Surprise 16
Phrases to Describe Excitement 19
Phrases to Describe Pain 22
Phrases to Describe Tiredness 25
Final Word from the Author 28
About the Author ..... **Error! Bookmark not defined.**
You might find these online courses helpful! 30

How to Use this Guide

Do you have difficulty writing compositions? Do you have difficulty finding the right words or phrases to use? Do you want to write better compositions?

Sure, you do. If not, you wouldn't have picked up this guide. Maybe your parents got this guide for you and they are now forcing you to read it.

Don't worry. This is not going to be your usual, boring assessment book. In fact, I purposely made it short and sweet so that you can get on with your life after your parents have forced you to finish reading this.

This guide is divided into 8 sections, with each section categorised under a certain emotion – Happiness, Sadness, Anger, Fear, Surprise, Excitement, Pain, Tiredness.

For each section, there will be 10 simple phrases that you can learn to express the emotional quality of your characters when you are writing a composition. I chose these emotions because they are the basic emotions of any human and your characters in the story would probably experience some of them as events unfold.

You will find these phrases simple, effective and easy-to-use for your writing. They will help you to express yourself better and add some colour to your story.

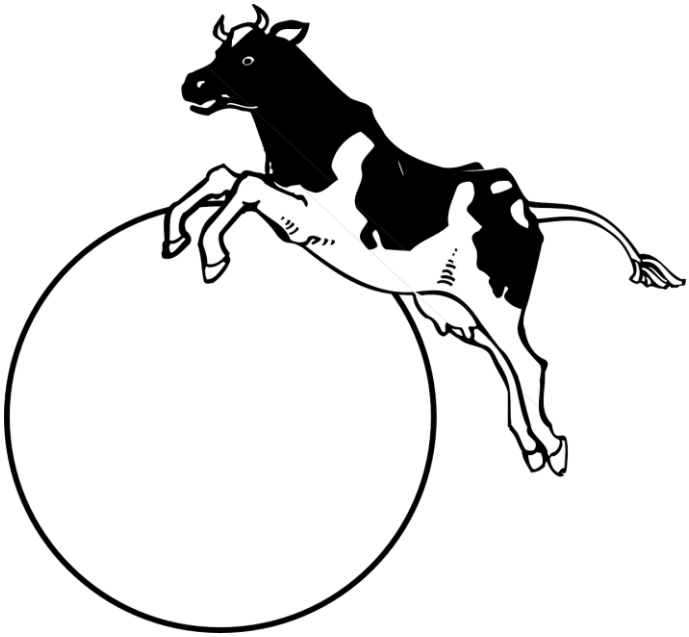
Refer to this guide every once in a while, to pick out a phrase to use for your composition assignments. Over time, these phrases will grow on you and you will start using them naturally, or even better, come up with your own!

Enjoy the writing process!

Phrases to Describe Happiness

1. **in a state of bliss** - complete happiness, spiritual joy
   a. *Eating the chocolate cake made by the famous pastry chef put me in a state of bliss.*
   b. *Jane was in a state of bliss after her boyfriend of five years proposed to her.*

2. **on cloud nine** – in a state of elation
   a. *Tom was on cloud nine when Mary agreed to go out on a date with him.*
   b. *Sally was on cloud nine after she graduated from college.*

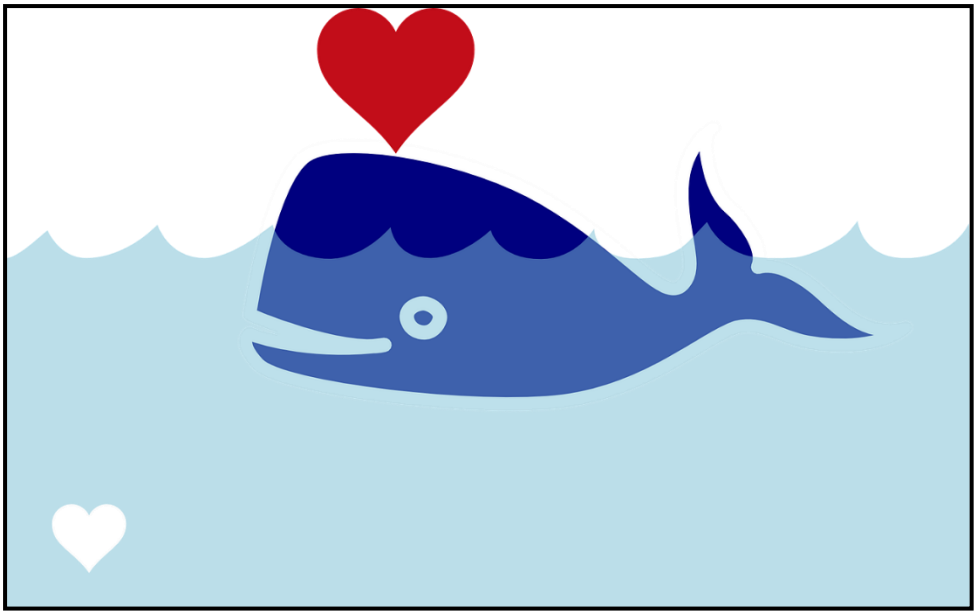


3. **over the moon** – extremely happy
   a. *When he found out that he had passed his English examinations, he was over the moon.*
   b. *John was over the moon when the announcer called out his lucky draw number..*

4. **dizzy with delight** – in a state of (uncontrollable) happiness
   a. *Jane was dizzy with delight when he found out that his parents had bought her a puppy.*
   b. *The boy was dizzy with delight to find out that he had won the competition.*

5. **jumping for joy** - action to show happiness
   a. *The children were jumping for joy when they found out that there was no school the next day.*
   b. *When his parents agreed to buy him a bicycle, he jumped for joy.*

6. **in high spirits** – in a good mood
   a. *The boys were in high spirits after they won the soccer match.*
   b. *In high spirits, the soldiers sang loudly as they marched.*



7. **having a whale of a time** - enjoying a really good time or event
   a. *The twins had a whale of a time at the theme park.*
   b. *Trust me, you will have a whale of time at this party.*

8. **seventh heaven** – eternal bliss (used as a hyperbole)
   a. *Tania was in seventh heaven when she found out that she got into the secondary school that she wanted.*
   b. *When the baby spoke her very first word, her mother was in seventh heaven.*

9. **grin from ear to ear** – smiling widely
   a. *He grinned from ear to ear when he unwrapped his present.*
   b. *The cheeky boy grinned from ear to ear as he thought of a really good prank to play on his friend.*

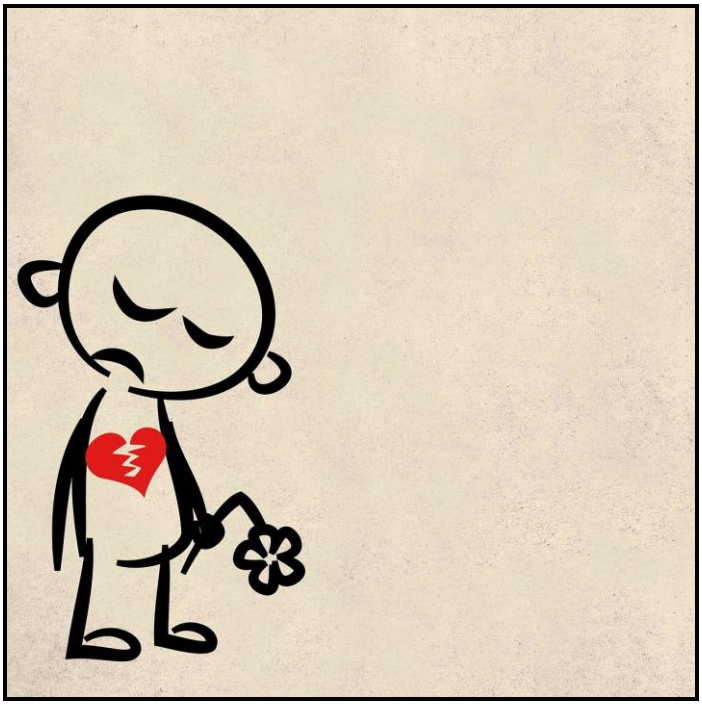
10. **walking on air** – elated or exuberantly joyful
    a. *Tony was walking on air when he found out that he got top in class*
    b. *He sure is walking on air today! I wonder what is the good news?*

Phrases to Describe Sadness

1. **down in the dumps** - gloomy, melancholic state of mind
   a. *Mr Tan was down in the dumps after he lost his job.*
   b. *Sofia was down in the dumps to find out that her pet cat had passed away*

2. **heart-rending** – causing great sadness / distress
   a. *She sang such a heart-rending version of that song that it made everyone in the room tear.*
   b. *When she heard the bad news, she let out a heart-rending wail and fell to her knees in grief*

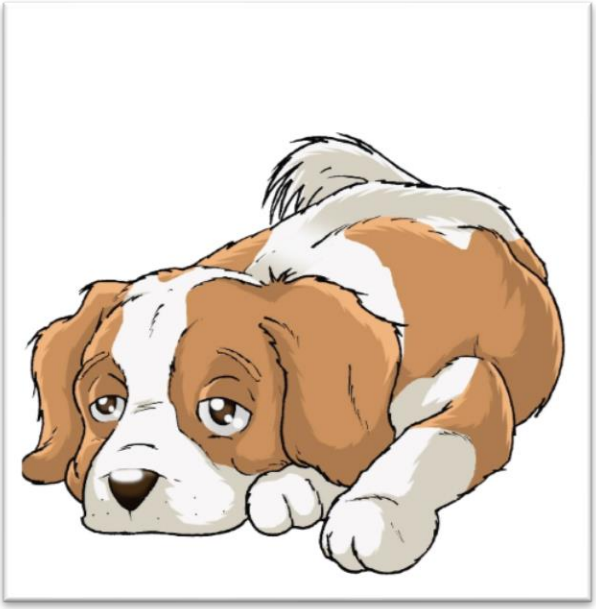
3. **feeling blue** – unhappy, depressed
   a. *He was feeling blue as he was left out from the class gathering.*
   b. *Feeling blue, Sharon locked herself in the room and ate ice-cream.*



4. **heavy-hearted / heavy heart** – feeling melancholic or depressed
   a. *After finding out that she had failed all her tests, Sally walked home with a heavy heart.*
   b. *John was heavy-hearted to find out that his team had lost the competition.*

5. **wretched with grief** – in a state of extreme sadness, grief-stricken
   a. *Lola was wretched with grief when she found out that her pet dog had died.*
   b. *Wretched with grief, the lady buried her face in her hands and started sobbing.*

6. **In the doldrums** – sluggish, in low spirits, dull, listless
   a. *Jack was in the doldrums after losing the match. He spent most of his time sleeping in his room.*
   b. *One the first day of school after the holidays, the teacher could sense that the entire class was in the doldrums.*



7. **bummed out** – upset, disappointed
   a. *He felt bummed out after being losing the badminton match.*
   b. *I am feeling bummed out from getting fired from my job.*

8. **reduced to tears** – make a person cry
   a. *When the Mr Lee reprimanded her for not handing up her homework, she was reduced to tears.*
   b. *The boxer was reduced to tears when he realised that he had lost the match.*

9. **crestfallen** – dispirited, dejected
   a. *He was crestfallen to find out that his application to his secondary school of choice was rejected.*
   b. *After losing the match, the players went home, crestfallen.*

10. **sinking feeling** - a feeling of uneasiness and apprehension
    a. *I have a sinking feeling that this idea will not work out well.*
    b. *The moment he heard the phone rang, he had a sinking feeling that something was not right.*

Phrases to Describe Anger

1. **blinded by rage** – unable to think clearly due to extreme anger
   a. *Blinded by rage, he threw his chair at the teacher.*
   b. *Tim was so blinded by rage that he shouted at his groupmates in front of the whole class.*

2. **go ballistic** – fly into a rage
   a. *Father went ballistic after he found out that I was suspended from school.*
   b. *I got some bad news for you but you must promise me that you will not go ballistic when you hear it.*

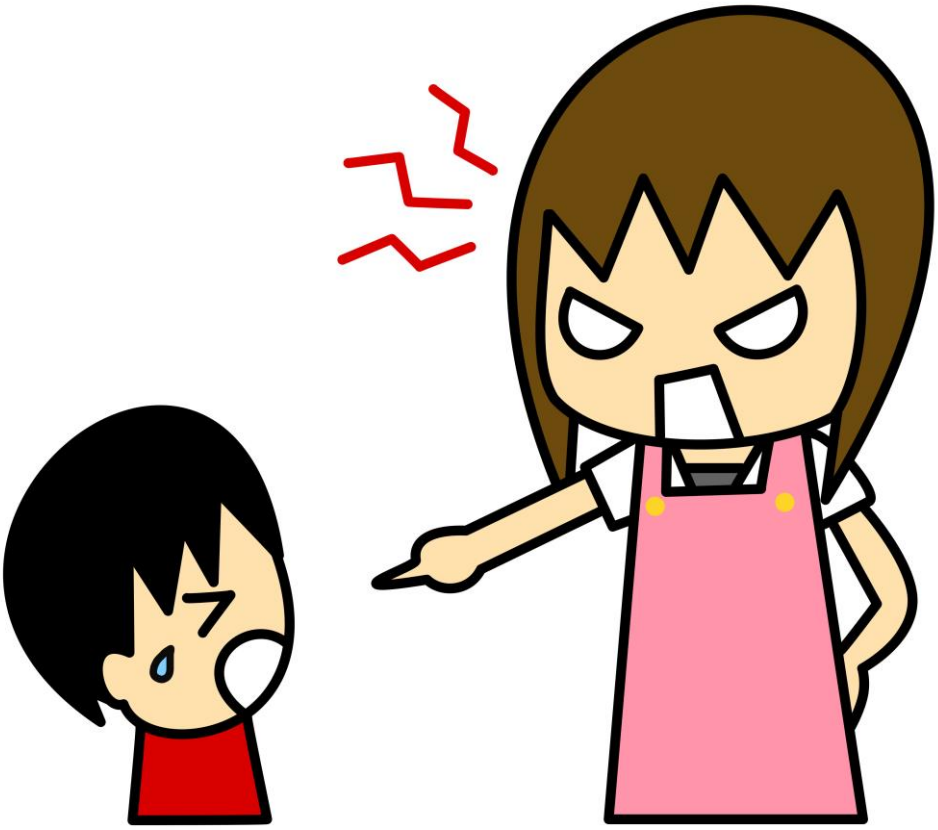
3. **burst a blood vessel** – to be very angry or frustrated over something
   a. *Mrs Lim nearly burst a blood vessel while marking the student's essays.*
   b. *If I talk to her again, I might burst a blood vessel*

4. **expressed outrage** - showed displeasure or anger
   a. *The public expressed outrage over the hiking of public transport fares.*
   b. *The workers expressed their outrage when the boss broke the news that their salaries will be cut this year.*

5. **on a warpath** – extremely angry and inclined to take action (often hostile)
   a. *Mr Toh was on a warpath the moment he found out that his car was vandalised.*
   b. *Stay away from him. Someone stole his hand phone and now he is on a warpath.*

6. **hissy fit** - a tantrum or an angry outburst
   a. *My younger sister threw a hissy fit when my parents refused to buy her the toy she wanted.*
   b. *Ignore her. She is throwing another one of her hissy fits.*

7. **animosity** – strong hostility, hatred
   a. *I do not know what I did to her to deserve such animosity!*
   b. *The senior students displayed animosity to the junior students who were sharing the basketball court with them.*



8. **tongue-lashing** – to give a scolding
   a. *Jon received a severe tongue lashing from our form teacher after he failed to hand up his homework for the third time.*
   b. *Father gave me a tongue lashing for failing my composition test.*

9. **exasperated** – infuriate, irritate intensely
   a. *Sally was exasperated by her mother's constant nagging.*
   b. *I am exasperated by her lousy working attitude!*

10. **blow your top off** - to lose your temper
    a. *The principal blew his top off when the boy argued back instead of apologising for his misdeeds.*
    b. *Take a step back and count to ten. You do not want to blow your top off and say things that you will regret later.*

Phrases to Describe Fear

1. **the heebie-jeebies** – a state of nervousness caused by fear or anxiety.
   a. *This place is giving me the heebie-jeebies.*
   b. *The moment I entered the store room, I got the heebie-jeebies.*

2. **blood run cold** – to be extremely frightened
   a. *When the robber whipped out his knife to my throat, my blood ran cold.*
   b. *Hearing her scream made my blood run cold*

3. **to get goose bumps** – bumps appearing on the skin due to cold or emotional stress.
   a. *Sally got goose bumps the moment she heard someone call her name out in the dark.*
   b. *That howling sound is giving me goosebumps!*

4. **deer caught in the headlights** – too frightened or surprised to move.
   a. *“Larry!” the teacher shouted. Larry immediately froze like a deer caught in the headlights.*
   b. *Like a deer caught in the headlights, Garren stood rooted to the ground with his jaw hanging open.*

5. **sense of foreboding** – feeling a sense of impending evil or misfortune.
   a. *When I entered the house, I felt a strong sense of foreboding.*
   b. *As she entered the lift with the stranger, she got a strong sense of foreboding.*

6. **your heart missed a beat** - to feel so frightened or excited that your heart beats faster.
   a. *Tom’s felt his heart miss a beat when he heard a loud, gruff voice behind him*
   b. *My heart missed a beat the moment that truck swerved out of nowhere!*

7. **on pins and needles** – nervous, in suspense
   a. *He was on pins and needles while waiting for his name to be called out.*
   b. *While waiting for the exam results to be released, the students were on pins and needles.*

8. **scared out of one's wits** – extremely frightened
   a. *Michelle was scared out of her wits when her brother jumped out of the closet with a mask.*
   b. *The loud explosion scared me out of my wits.*

9. **shake like a leaf** – to tremble intensely from fear
   a. *She could not stop herself from shaking like a leaf as she hid under her bed.*
   b. *The hostage started to shake like a leaf when the robber pressed his knife up against her throat.*

10. **hyperventilate** – to breathe abnormally fast or deep
    a. *When she saw the amount of blood she lost, she started hyperventilating.*
    b. *The victim was still hyperventilating from the shock when the police arrived at the scene.*

Phrases to Describe Surprise

1. **at a loss for words** – too surprised to speak
   a. *I was at a loss for words when she gave me a surprise present!*
   b. *I don't know what to say. I didn't expect to win so I am at a loss for words right now.*

2. **dumbstruck** - too surprised to speak
   a. *I was dumbstruck when the host announced that I have won the first prize.*
   b. *He was dumbstruck by the subsequent string of events that happened within a few seconds.*

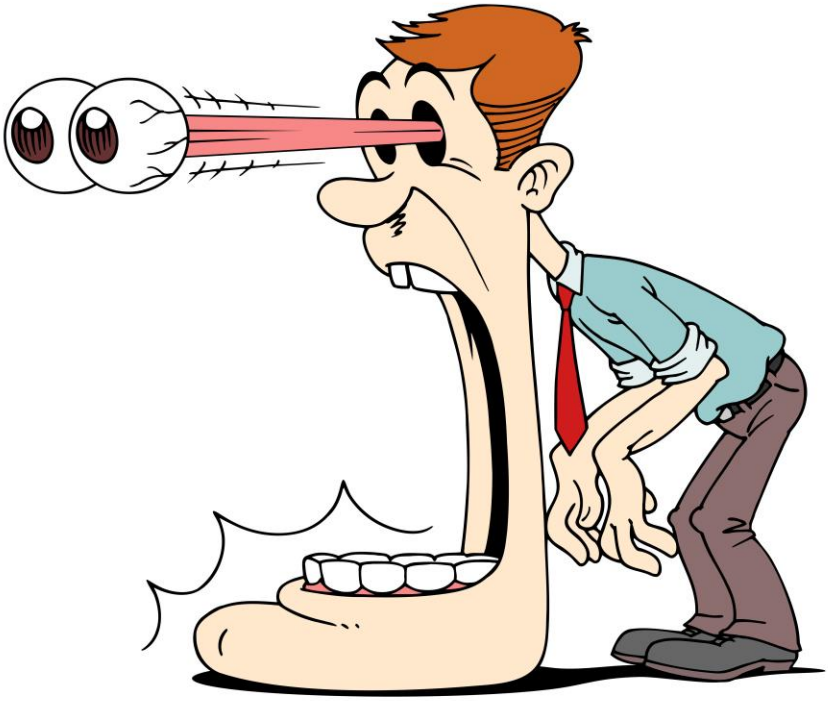
3. **taken aback** – surprised or confused
   a. *I was taken aback by the news!*
   b. *Laura was taken aback by the rude actions of the sales staff.*

4. **dropped the bombshell** – make an unexpected or shattering announcement
   a. *Toby dropped the bombshell during dinner. He told his parents that he had to be retained for failing all his exams.*
   b. *She dropped the bombshell by revealing that she was three months pregnant.*

5. **caught off guard** - to surprise someone by doing something unexpected
   a. *The defender was caught off guard by striker's sudden speed.*
   b. *Willy was caught off guard by the bully's sudden attack.*

6. **flabbergasted** – astonished, astounded
   a. *He was flabbergasted by the queue he saw outside his shop.*
   b. *Karen was flabbergasted when she saw the decorations in her house.*

7. **stupefied** – astonished, unable to think properly
   a. *His mother was stupefied when she realised that her son was the one performing the daredevil stuns.*
   b. *Stupefied by what his friend had just done, Bob stood there with his mouth agape.*

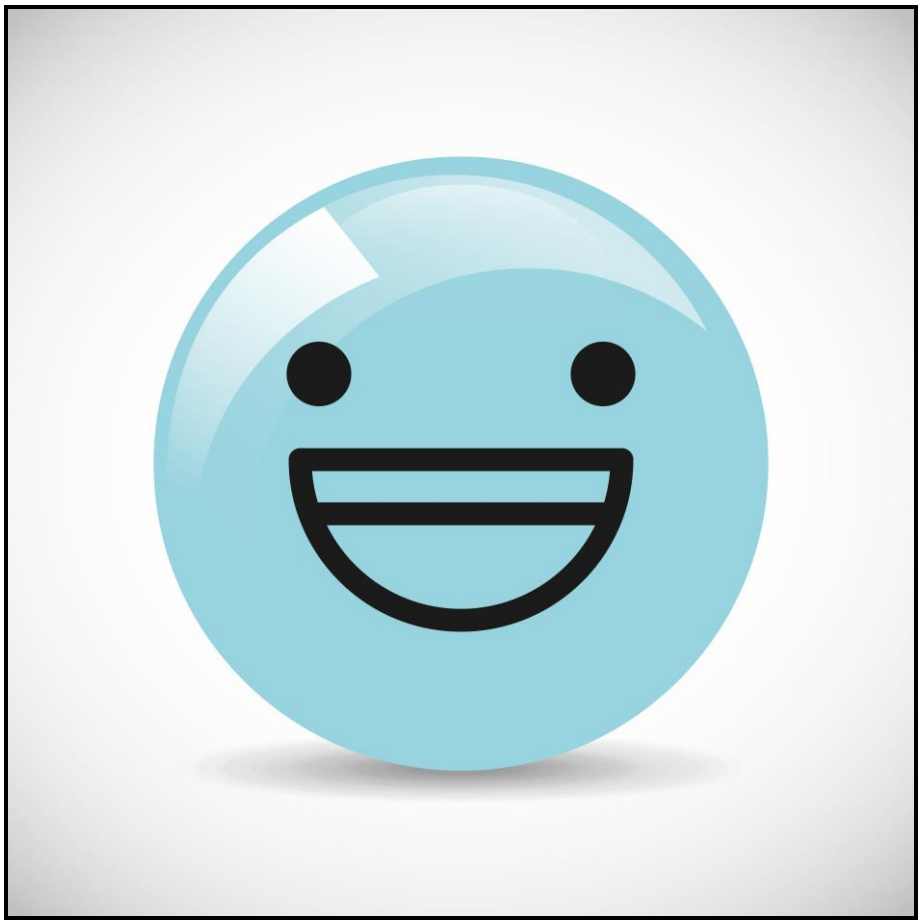


8. **jaw-dropping** – amazing
   a. *Hilary is able to perform some jaw-dropping stunts on her skateboard!*
   b. *The acrobat did some jaw-dropping moves to entertain the audience.*

9. **confound** – to cause surprise and confusion
   a. *The teacher was confounded when she found out that her naughtiest student was the top scorer in class.*
   b. *All the students were confounded by the essay topic they were tasked to write during the exams.*

10. **out of the blue** – without warning, unexpectedly
    a. *Out of the blue, there was a very loud crash.*
    b. *The car came swerving into my lane out of the blue.*

Phrases to Describe Excitement



1. **bounce off the walls** – full of nervous energy and excitement
   a. *The children were bouncing off the walls when the teacher told them that they were going on a field trip.*
   b. *After hearing the good news, she was bouncing off the walls.*

2. **adrenaline pumping** – a high state of excitement
   a. *As the starter gun sounded off, my adrenaline started pumping.*
   b. *His adrenaline started pumping when the competition began.*

3. **buzz** - sense of excitement, kick
   a. *Nothing beats the buzz of scoring a three-pointer shot in basketball!*
   b. *The teenagers got a buzz from sitting that roller-coaster.*

4. **ripple of excitement** – a series of quiet but excited murmurs
   a. *A ripple of excitement spread through the hall before the principal was about to make the announcement of school closure the coming Friday.*
   b. *The news caused a ripple of excitement to spread among the students.*

5. **cause a stir** – to cause unusual interest or excitement
   a. *The loud bang in the corridor caused a stir and soon everyone was running out from the classroom.*
   b. *Richard brought his pet dog to school and caused quite a stir.*

6. **pumped** – extremely enthusiastic
   a. *I am so pumped for my performance later on!*
   b. *Felicia was feeling pretty pumped for the competition.*

7. **burst with excitement** – to have a strong feeling of excitement
   a. *When she heard the news, she burst with excitement.*
   b. *The children burst with excitement when they found out that they were going on an excursion.*

8. **eager beaver** - an enthusiastic person
   a. *James is an eager beaver who will finish the entire group project himself!*
   b. *During the math class, Tobias transforms into an eager beaver as it is his best subject.*

9. **fervour** – intense, passionate feeling
   a. *The pop star brought the audience to a fervour with her most popular songs.*
   b. *The crowd displayed a patriotic fervour during the National Day celebrations.*

10. **zeal** – great energy and enthusiasm in pursuing something
    a. *He possessed tremendous zeal in achieving his dreams.*
    b. *The zealous fans thronged the stage to get the pop star's autograph.*

Phrases to Describe Pain

1. **gruelling** – tiring and demanding
   a. *The long, gruelling marathon put many runners to the test.*
   b. *This is a gruelling job. Are you sure you can take it?*

2. **torment** – to undergo physical pain or mental anguish
   a. *Going through 4 periods of math class in one day is just a torment!*
   b. *Tormented by his past, the ex-convict had difficulty sleeping at night.*

3. **lacerations** – deep cuts or tear in flesh
   a. *She suffered some lacerations after falling off her motorcycle.*
   b. *Blood was flowing out from the lacerations in his leg.*

4. **tender** – painful, sore
   a. *My knee was still tender from that fall.*
   b. *Don't touch my arm! It is still tender.*

5. **writhed** – twisting, squirming contortions of the body
   a. *The injured player was writhing on the grass and groaning in pain.*
   b. *Clutching his stomach, the boy writhed in pain.*

6. **agonising** – extremely painful or distressful
   a. *The parents had a long, agonising wait outside the surgery room while their child was being operated on.*
   b. *The pain was so agonising that he was groaning every few minutes.*

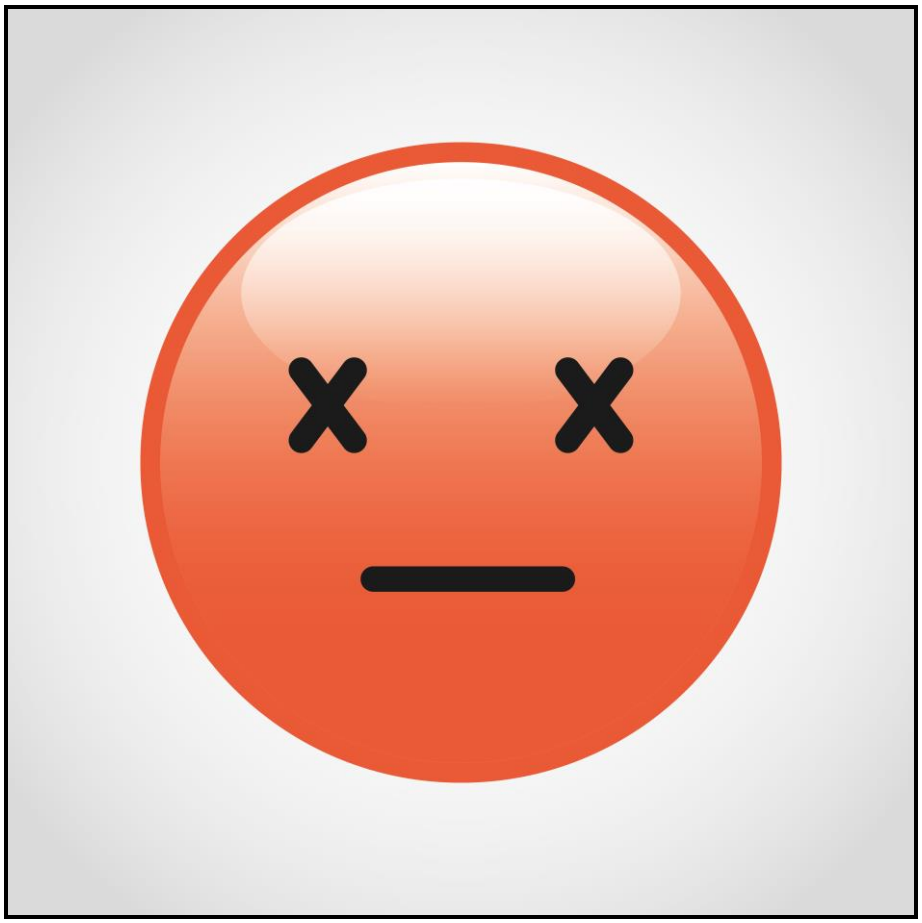
7. **excruciating** – intensely painful
   a. *The pain was so excruciating that he screamed like a little girl.*
   b. *An excruciating pain shot through my ribs.*

8. **throbbing** – strong regular rhythm
   a. *I have a throbbing headache.*
   b. *His arm throbbed in pain.*

9. **pain the neck** – a nuisance
   a. *That lady is such a pain in the neck. I hope she goes away!*
   b. *Elliot can be a real pain in the neck to work with.*

10. **torturous** – causing suffering
    a. *After the torturous training, the soldiers were finally allowed to rest.*
    b. *The torturous heat caused many of the runners to faint halfway.*

Phrases to Describe Tiredness



1. **dead tired** – extremely weary
   a. *Father was dead tired after working overtime till 12 midnight.*
   b. *I am dead tired from studying the whole of last night.*

2. **sleep like a log** – to sleep deeply or soundly
   a. *I slept like a log last night. I did not even realise that my radio was turned on!*
   b. *Mother tried to wake him up but he carried on sleeping like a log.*

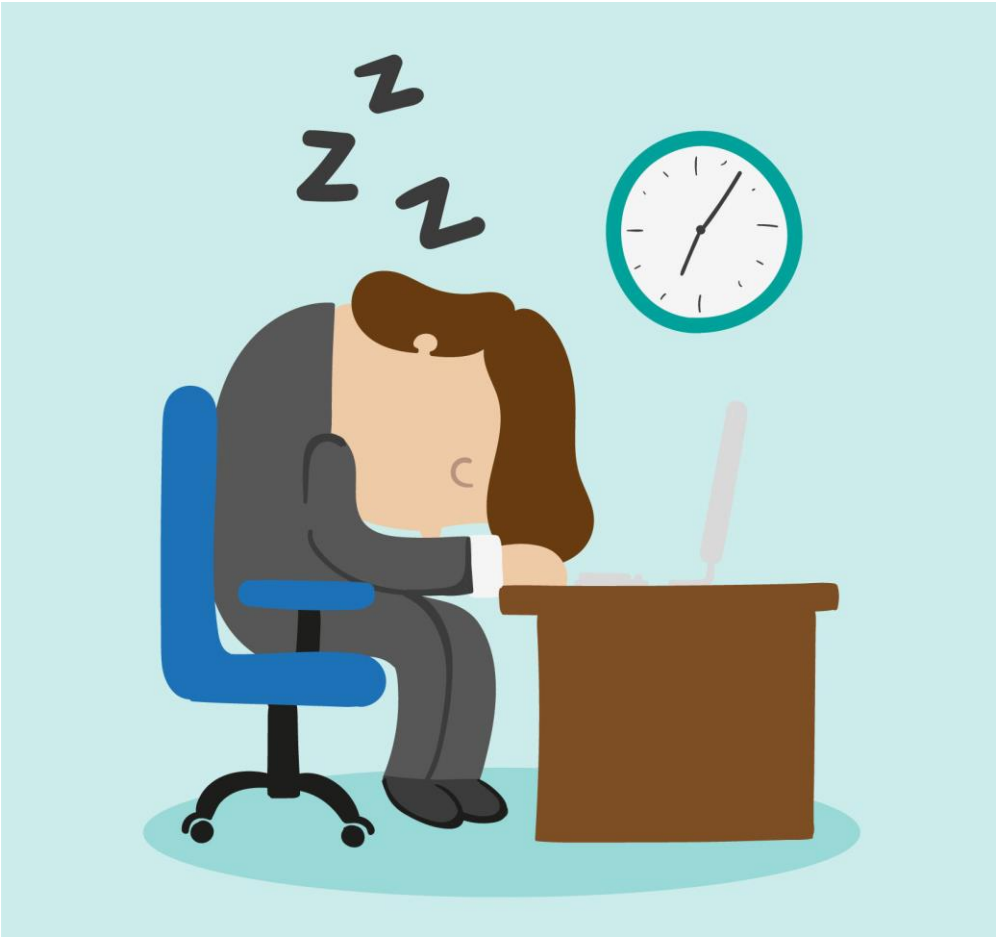
3. **worn out** – exhausted
   a. *I am worn out from solving problem after problem.*
   b. *When the entire day was over, Kelly felt worn out.*

4. **burn out** – become exhausted
   a. *Do take a break from studying! You do not want to get burned out!*
   b. *He was feeling burned out from all the school projects he had to complete.*

5. **ready to drop** – nearly too exhausted and may fall asleep any moment
   a. *After 3 hours of badminton and 2 hours of soccer, Jimmy was ready to drop.*
   b. *I was ready to drop by the time I got home.*

6. **hit the sack** – go to bed
   a. *I have to hit the sack early tonight as I have a big test tomorrow.*
   b. *It is time to hit the sack. Training resumes early tomorrow.*

7. **dog-tired** – extremely tired
   a. *Sophie was dog-tired after one whole day of orientation games.*
   b. *I am dog-tired after teaching back-to-back classes.*



8. **out like a light** – to fall asleep quickly
   a. *The moment he sat down, he was out like a light.*
   b. *Few minutes into the show, Dave was already out like a light.*

9. **dead on one's feet** – extremely weary
   a. *Robert was dead on his feet after working for 8 hours without break.*
   b. *After 4 hours of dance practice, I was dead on my feet.*

10. **drained** – tired
    a. *After teaching non-stop for 8 hours, the teacher was completely drained.*
    b. *Noel was drained from the long-distance travelling.*

Final Word from the Author

When Primary School students write their essays, they tend to jump from one scene to another, or one action to another, without stopping to consider the emotions of the characters in their story.

Use this guide to remind yourself to focus on the character's feelings or emotions. This will give more "life" to the story and the readers will be able to forge an emotional bond with the characters.

Do refer to this guide every now and then when you are writing a composition. Try using a new phrase or word for every new composition. This will not only help to expand your vocabulary but also allows you to experiment with different ways of writing.

Once you have learned how to use these phrases and you are comfortable with them, you will notice that your writing will flow more smoothly, and you will soon be able to write with flair.

Of course, there are many more creative words and phrases out there! When you do come across some, highlight it or note down its usage and apply it to your writing next time.

To be a good writer, you must never stop learning!

Happy Writing!

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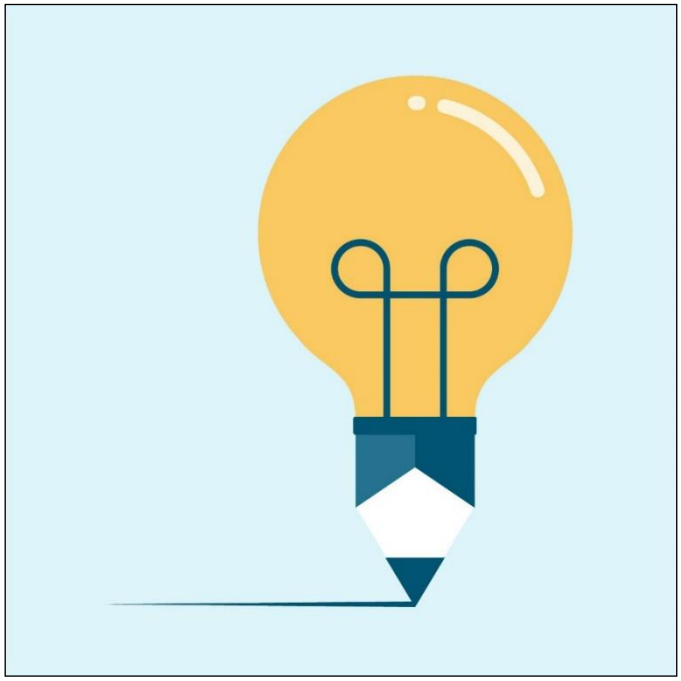

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